unedifying (and unwittingly hilarious) spectacle of castes fighting with each other to be declared backward: the competitive zeal of the Meenas and the Gujjars in Rajasthan to be deemed more backward than each other, and the agitations of privileged and powerful castes like the Marathas, the Patels and the Jats for reservations on the same basis, would be funny if all sides weren't so deadly serious. As an uncle of mine sagely observed, 'In our country now, you can't go forward unless you're a backward.' (That may seem a prejudiced remark, but such views are increasingly held by many whose castes are ineligible for reservations). Caste—ironically entrenched in India by British colonial rule, as I wrote in *Inglorious Empire*—has remained an inescapable feature of our lives.

The news that a recent survey has established that 27 per cent of Indians still practise caste Untouchability[4] is not, in many ways, news at all. Most Indians have grown up in an India where we have seen such behaviour, though the kind of people who read English-language books probably think of it as something that happens in rural, backward villages rather than bigger towns and cities.

But this survey also packs a few other surprises. It shows almost every third Hindu (30 per cent) admitted to the practice. That is, they refused to allow Dalits into their kitchen or to use their utensils. But data from the survey showed that Untouchability was also practised by Sikhs (23 per cent), Muslims (18 per cent) and Christians (5 per cent).[5] These are faiths that pride themselves on their enshrining of equality and the brotherhood of faith. Dr Amit Thorat, the survey's lead researcher, was quoted in the Indian media as saying, 'These findings indicate that conversion [to religions other than Hinduism] has not led to the total change of mindset that was hoped…caste identity is sticky baggage, difficult to dislodge in social settings.'[6]

My father's and my response—to be oblivious to caste and indifferent to the caste associations of friends, employees and associates—is no longer enough in today's caste-conscious India. For a long time I assumed this was the modern Indian ideal—the egalitarian spirit in which one judged people not by their caste but (to borrow from Martin Luther King Jr.) by the content of their character or the sum of their